END OF COLD WAR: THE NEW DÉTENTE

The ascendancy of Gorbachev as the President of the Soviet Union marked a new beginning in the East–West relations. His ascendancy to the Presidency paved the way for agreements on nuclear and conventional forces. The Geneva Summit of 19–21 November 1985 was the first Soviet–American summit held after the outbreak of the Afghanistan crisis. Here, both USA and the Soviet Union focussed on the need for preventing any sort of war—nuclear or conventional—between them. The Reykjavik Summit of 11–12 October 1986 was the Second Summit where President Reagan and President Gorbachev met to discuss various major problems of international politics and other issues of mutual interest. This was followed by the pathbreaking Washington Summit of 7–10 December 1987. In 1987, Gorbachev travelled to the United States and signed the Intermediate Range Nuclear Forces (INF) Treaty banning intermediate range nuclear missiles including Cruise and Pershing II missiles. Gorbachev and Reagan met at the Moscow Summit of May 1988, and the Malta Summit of 1989 marked a new beginning in the US and USSR relations as well as in international politics. A host of summits followed between Gorbachev and the new American President George Bush (Sr.) symbolizing several agreements on arms control, trade and also the question of German reunification. There was also the Helsinki Summit regarding the Gulf Crisis of 1990, but the most important breakthrough came in the Moscow Summit of 1991 and signing of Strategic Arms Reduction Treaty (START). In July 1991, President Bush and President Gorbachev signed the START for deep cuts in their strategic arsenals.[18] The Conventional Forces in Europe (CFE) Treaty also reduced the Soviet presence in Europe. The Soviet Union also agreed to withdraw their aid and support to Cuba, Afghanistan and Eastern Europe. All these developments signalled the beginning of the end of Cold War.

In 1991 and early 1992, President Bush declared massive unilateral nuclear arms cut and this was matched by Russia by substantial reduction in the former Soviet nuclear arsenal. He had proclaimed the end of Cold War in the early nineties but, on 1 February 1992, President Bush and the visiting Russian Federation President, Boris